SOUTH AFRICA'S BRICS MOMENT

A BRIDGE BETWEEN WORLDS

Gillian Schutte, writer and filmmaker

The tectonic plates of global power are shifting. Western dominance, long sustained through financial control and military reach, is losing its unchallenged grip. Emerging powers are building new institutions, forging new alliances, and crafting alternative visions of the future. At the centre of this unfolding story stands BRICS — no longer a loose acronym, but a living formation shaping the contours of a multipolar world.

And at the southern tip of Africa stands a country uniquely placed to anchor this shift: South Africa.



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A historic bridge

South Africa's entry into BRICS in 2010 was never just about numbers. It was about symbolism, history and strategy. It brought liberation credentials forged in the anti-apartheid struggle, a unique position on the African continent, and a capacity to speak to multiple worlds. Its inclusion ensured that Africa — the youngest, most resource-rich and geopolitically decisive continent of this century — was not left outside the multipolar conversation.

South Africa became the bridge: between the Global South and North, between continental aspirations and global realignments, and between historical resistance and future possibility.

The BRICS vision

Over the past decade, BRICS has quietly laid the groundwork for a parallel global order. It has established the New Development Bank, advanced de-dollarisation by encouraging trade settlements in local currencies, and is actively exploring the creation of alternative payment platforms that reduce reliance on Western financial systems. It has also opened for non-Western scientific, technological and energy cooperation. The bloc is expanding rapidly, attracting states that no longer want to be confined to the orbit of a single power centre.

In this unfolding architecture, South Africa's role is not ornamental. It has hosted pivotal summits, brokered delicate diplomatic conversations, and, crucially, opened the doors for African states to shape global decisions. The 2023 Johannesburg Summit, where BRICS expanded to include Saudi Arabia, Egypt, the UAE, Ethiopia, and Iran, was a moment of historical weight — and Pretoria was at the heart of it.

Energy and industrial renaissance

South Africa's industrial and energy capacity gives it another layer of strategic importance. The country holds advanced nuclear infrastructure, deep mineral wealth, and industrial know-how that, if aligned with BRICS partners, could underpin a regional economic revival.

Chinese investment in infrastructure, Russian expertise in nuclear energy, Indian innovation in pharmaceuticals and digital systems — these are structures already taking shape. They are opportunities to rebuild what neoliberalism decimated: railways, energy grids, ports, factories and technological capacity.

Through BRICS, South Africa can shift from a model of extraction and dependency to one of co-development and shared sovereignty. It can help forge industrial corridors that run from the Atlantic to the Indian Ocean, powered by African resources but owned in partnership, not controlled from abroad.

Diplomatic leverage

South Africa's diplomatic role is equally critical. It stands as a mediator with historical links to the West, yet deep ties to the Global South. It can speak both languages, and that makes it an indispensable balancer in a world where the risk of hardened blocs is real. Rather than being a passive player, South Africa can actively shape conversations, translating continental positions into global strategies.

Claiming the stage

The world is watching. BRICS has grown from five to a powerful constellation of 10 member states, representing the majority of humanity. New institutions are taking shape. New rules are being written. South Africa is not a bystander in this process, it is one of the architects.

The question now is whether it will claim this moment fully. Will it move beyond procedural diplomacy and step into visionary leadership? Will it leverage its energy sovereignty, its industrial backbone and its continental legitimacy to shape the future, not simply follow it?

South Africa's BRICS moment is here. It is a chance to step onto the world stage not as a junior partner, but as a bridge between worlds — Africa's voice in a multipolar order. History rarely offers such moments twice.